

using copper pot stills, and aged in French oak barrels for a minimum of two years. The distillation results in what is called eau-de-vie (or water of life). “Regardless of age, eaux-de-vie remain known as such until they’re blended together. The blending, therefore, is a key factor that takes myriad eaux-de-vie and turns them collectively into an exclusive blend such as the Louis XIII,” says Le Mestres. “The challenge that the cellar master has is to recreate that exact blend from 1874 (when the first decanter of Louis XIII was released). The whole complexity is to recreate something knowing that your raw material will vary from one year to another, depending on the grapes growing and weather conditions every year,” he adds. Louis XIII is made from a blend of up to 1,200 individual eaux-de-vie, using grapes grown in the Grande Champagne region of Cognac, making it an extremely complex drink. Little wonder, this very special cognac named after the 17th-century French King—who was the first French monarch to recognise cognac as a category of brandy in its own right—is one of the most expensive cognacs sold, with a decanter priced at ₹3.50 lakh in Delhi.

Some of the largest cognac brands formed pretty early. Martell, the oldest continually operational cognac brand, has a history stretching back to 1715; Rémy Martin came into play in 1724; and Hennessy in 1765. Courvoisier is the “newest” on the scene. It started production in the Cognac region only in 1828.

Today, Hennessy, part of the LVMH group, is by far the largest distiller, accounting for roughly 69 per cent of global sales volume according to Statista. It is followed by Martell (part of Pernod Ricard), Rémy Martin (from family-owned business group Rémy Cointreau) and Courvoisier (part of Beam Suntory). The global cognac market is



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valued at \$5.5 billion in 2022 and is expected to reach \$10.2 billion by 2032, growing at a CAGR of 6.4 per cent from 2022 to 2032, as per market research company Fact MR.

Hennessy’s most coveted cognac is the limited edition Richard Hennessy, named after the army man who built the Maison Hennessy. Offered in a hand-blown decanter in Baccarat crystal, the blend is made from some of the scarcest eaux-de-vie in Hennessy’s reserves. A decanter is priced for ₹5 lakh in Gurugram and ₹5.46 lakh in Mumbai.

Unlike whisky that has an age

statement depending upon how many years it has been aged in the cask, cognac has differing grades, shown by V.S, V.S.O.P, X.O, etc. V.S., or Very Special, is a cognac that has been aged for at least two years in oak barrels. Very Superior Old Pale, V.S.O.P., is an older cognac—its youngest eaux-de-vie being aged for a minimum of four years—and is paler in colour compared to the V.S. Finally, the X.O. or Extra Old, designates a blend that has been aged for a minimum of ten years. Earlier this was six years but in 2018, new classifications came into place.